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THE PRINCESS WHO RESCUED HERSELF



A bedtime fairytale about writing your own happily ever after.

BY MK PARRISH • \$14

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A NOTE BEFORE THE STORY

Every fairytale you have ever heard has a tower in it, and a girl in the tower, and someone else coming to get her out.

This one has a tower too. But the girl inside it has been thinking.

Read it slowly. Read it out loud if you can. And when you get to the end, ask the small person listening the question the whole story is really about:

what would you do, if the door was locked and nobody was coming? You may be surprised what they already know.

THE PRINCESS WHO RESCUED HERSELF

Once, at the top of a tall grey tower, there lived a princess named Wren.

The tower had one round window and one heavy door, and the door was locked from the outside. Everyone in the kingdom knew the story, because it was a very old story and it was always told the same way: *one day a brave prince will climb the tower, and open the door, and the princess will be free, and then the story can finally end.*

So Wren waited. That was her job. That was, everyone agreed, the whole point of her.

She waited on Monday. She waited on Tuesday. She waited through a whole grey winter, watching the road for a horse.

And princes came. Oh, they came.

The first prince rode up on a white horse and looked at the locked door and said, "This looks difficult," and rode away to find an easier tower.

The second prince stood at the bottom and shouted up, "Do not worry! I am here to rescue you!" — and then he sat down on a rock to rest from all his shouting, and fell asleep, and in the morning he had forgotten which tower it was.

The third prince did not come at all. He had heard the tower was very tall.

And Wren sat by the round window with her chin in her hands, and something in her that had been quiet for a long time finally spoke up.

Why, thought Wren, *am I waiting for someone who keeps not coming?*

It was a small thought. But small thoughts, in towers, echo.

She got up. She walked to the heavy door and looked at it properly for the first time — really looked, the way you look at something when you have decided it is *yours to solve* and not somebody else's. The lock was on the outside. But the hinges — the hinges were on the *inside*.

Nobody had ever mentioned the hinges.

"Well," said Wren, out loud, to no prince at all. "Isn't that interesting."

She did not have a sword. She had a hairpin, and a candlestick, and a very great deal of time she had planned to spend waiting. She used all three. She worked at the bottom hinge until her fingers ached, and then she rested, and then she worked at it some more. The tower was quiet. No horse came up the road. And Wren discovered something that surprised her more than any prince ever had:

She did not mind the quiet. In the quiet, she could hear herself think. And her own thoughts, it turned out, were good company — cleverer than she had been told, braver than she had believed.

By the time the moon was high, the bottom hinge came loose with a groan.

By the time the birds woke up, the top one did too.

And Wren pushed — not at the lock, she left the silly lock exactly where it was — she pushed at the *hinged* side, and the great heavy door swung the wrong way entirely, the way nobody had ever expected a door to swing, and fell open into the morning.

Wren stood at the top of her tower with the wind in her hair and the whole green kingdom spread out below her, gold at the edges where the sun was coming up.

She had not been rescued. She had been *paying attention*.

And here is the part of the story the old version never had. As Wren walked down the long stairs and out into the waking kingdom, she was not angry at the princes. She almost felt sorry for them, still out there looking for towers to be heroes at, when the whole time the tower had belonged to the person *inside* it.

She met the first prince on the road. He was very startled to see her walking freely about.

"But — who rescued you?" he asked.

Wren thought about it. Then she smiled, and she told him the truth, which was the best thing she had learned in the tower and is the best thing in this whole book:

"I did."

And she walked on into her own morning, in no particular hurry, because it was hers now, all of it — the road, the kingdom, the story. Especially the story.

She had picked up the pen, and she had written herself a door.

THE END — AND YOUR BEGINNING

Wren's tower is not real. But the locked door is.

Everybody, even someone very small, will someday find themselves in a moment that feels stuck — a friendship gone wrong, a fear that won't quiet down, a day when it seems like the only thing to do is wait for a rescue that isn't coming.

This is the story to remember on that day.

You do not have to wait at the window. You are allowed to look for the hinges. You are cleverer than the story other people tell about you, and braver than you have been told, and the pen — the one that writes what happens next — has been in your own hand the whole time.

Go find your door.

You are the one you have been waiting for.

This is the first tale in **The Little Rewrites** *— bedtime stories from MK Parrish for children who are learning that they get to write their own happily ever after. More stories, and the free read-aloud guide for grown-ups, are waiting at* **mkparrish.com.**

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